



No more Hotel TV

TVs have always existed in hotel rooms but regular TV may not be appealing anymore
<http://dgit.in/11dsZSA>

NUC, ITX or ATX?

New standards can get so confusing at times. Which is the right form factor for you?
<http://dgit.in/18zhmYd>

playing back files should not be an issue. The system should also be able to access a NAS device or other form of networked storage.

- Streaming: The PC should be able to stream data to and from your devices.
- Gaming: This is a no-brainer. Any decent PC should be able to play games and play them well. We don't want to see lag on a 60" plasma screen.
- Internet access: The PC should be able to give you hassle-free internet access.

What we need to do is find a system that does all of the above in the most convenient way possible. The most obvious choice is Windows 8. The Metro UI is a pain to use on a standard desktop, but as a HTPC with a proper remote control, it can be more functional. Also, the Windows platform can offer you a gaming experience that is unmatched by any other currently available. That said, a Windows 8 license is expensive and it's not like Linux doesn't have some great games (Steam anyone?). Here are some of the more viable options that you have:

1. Windows 8 PRO with Windows Media Centre: This is probably one of the more expensive options. Windows 8 will cost you about ₹13,550 for a PRO license with Windows Media Centre. Couple this purchase with a Media Centre remote that costs upwards of ₹2,000 and you have one of the most convenient media centre systems that you can have. All you have to do is organize your media, dump it into the media libraries and you're set. The remote will help you navigate the Media Centre Interface and all your media will be accessible and playable from there. You can also configure your Xbox controller with software such as Xpadder to remap the controller.
2. Windows 8 with Metro apps: Windows 8's Metro UI is an absolute pain in the neck on a PC, but when it comes to a HTPC UI, it's one of the best and most powerful options at your disposal. If your media library is well-organized, you'll be able to access it with ease. And, being a Windows platform, gaming is never going to be an issue. In our opinion, this is the most convenient option.

3. Windows 8 with iTunes: iTunes is actually a very viable Media Centre option if you have an iDevice. You'll already have iTunes if you have an iDevice, just login with your Apple ID > click on the Menu button > Library > Turn on Home Sharing > Enter Apple ID again. That's it. You can now stream your entire iTunes library to your iDevice or control your library via the "iTunes Remote" app on your iDevice. Just make sure that your PC and device are on the same network. Remember that iTunes only supports a select few formats and if you have a large collection of FLAC files or videos in mkv or some other unsupported format, you won't be able to import them into iTunes.
4. Windows 8 with XBMC/MediaPortal: Both XBMC and MediaPortal are excellent media centre systems. You can read more about XBMC in the workshop that we've published, all

Digit's HTPC-sized PC

CPU	Intel Core i5 4430
Motherboard	ASUS H87i PLUS
GPU	ASUS NVIDIA GeForce 650Ti Boost
RAM	4GBx2 ADATA Gaming series AX3U2400GC4G10-DG2
Storage	ADATA SP900 256GB SSD
PSU	Cooler Master Silent Pro Gold 550W
Cabinet	Cooler Master Elite 120 Advanced

we'll say here is that it's an excellent option for a media centre. Media Portal is a good media centre in itself and an alternative to XBMC. It shares a lot of features with XBMC and choosing between the two is more a question of aesthetics than anything else.

5. XBMCUbuntu: XBMC is available for linux, but XBMCUbuntu integrates Ubuntu and XBMC to give you a stand-alone OS. Configuring this setup can be a pain if you're unfamiliar with linux, but the XBMC forums are always there to help you. This is probably the best option for a powerful media centre that costs nothing in terms of software. Couple this with the linux version of steam, you can enjoy some great gaming as well.

A media centre remote

Setting up a remote for your PC is a very simple task. You can take the easy way out and just purchase a media centre remote, or, you can use your existing smartphone to setup a wireless remote control.

- Remote control apps: Apps like RemotePC or VLC remote will allow you to setup a virtual remote for your PCs. Just search for "remote" on the Play Store or App Store and you'll be inundated with options. Most will ask you to setup a server on your PC that will grant your phone access to the PC.
- iDevices: We've mentioned this earlier, but if all your media is on iTunes, all you need is an iDevice and iTunes Remote and you have full access and control over your media library.
- IR blasters: These are present on a handful of mobile devices, but you can get third-party add-ons as well. These are a little hard to find in India, but if you have a kindly relative who's coming from abroad somewhere, you can probably get one at a decent price (l5remote.com for example).

That's it! With the right hardware and apps, you've got the ideal HTPC on your hands. One that is no slouch when it comes to gaming, but can also provide you with a compelling multimedia experience. A PC that can hide in the background when it's not needed, but can give you all the power that you've grown up with when you do. PCs need no longer be banned from the living room.

Digit's HTPC configuration

The configuration of the PC that we built is mentioned here and it didn't cost us more than ₹68,000. As you can see, the hardware isn't ridiculously high-end, but is a more sensible combination of price and function. The choice of motherboard is especially important as it will determine your connectivity options.

In our tests, we got over 50fps in Arkham City at 1080p high settings and PhysX set to high, we also managed over 60fps in Borderlands 2 at 1080p and max. settings. You don't need to stick to this configuration of course, mix and match to build the PC. Don't forget to put up your HTPC at <http://dgit.in/18CQIGG>. 